

prompted suspicions that the Nazis were behind the arson, given that they had so much to gain from discrediting the communists.

The next day, the Reichstag Fire Decree banned the Communist Party. Hitler's response fed on fears of a communist takeover, and many Germans believed that Hitler's decisive action had saved the nation. By April, under pressure from the Nazis, the Enabling Act was passed by the Reichstag. This granted Hitler the right to make his own laws without involving the Reichstag, and it solidified his place as a fascist dictator with complete control over Germany.

Dictators seize power

Fascism emerged across Europe in the 1920s and '30s. As governments struggled with post-war economic hardship and the fear of communist revolutions, extreme right-wing movements—fascism in Italy and Nazism in Germany—were set up as defenders against communism. They used paramilitary groups to intimidate opponents, and spread propaganda to gain popularity. In Italy, Benito Mussolini was seen as the only man able to restore order. Once appointed prime minister in 1922, Mussolini gradually assumed dictatorial powers, becoming *Il Duce*, the leader. By 1928, Italy was a totalitarian state.

In Germany, Hitler worked ceaselessly to transform the Nazis into a major political force. Relying on a mix of nationalist rhetoric, anti-communism, vicious



The Reichstag

Fire is said to have burned so fiercely that flames could be seen for miles around. Hitler blamed the communists in an attempt to build support for his Nazi Party.

anti-Semitism, and an unceasing call to reverse the peace terms made at Versailles in 1919, Hitler rode a wave of popularity. In 1933 he became Chancellor, then, shortly after, dictator, calling himself *Führer*.

Fascists united

In 1936, Hitler and Mussolini began to send military support to aid General Franco in the Spanish Civil War, which pitted right-wing nationalists against left-wing republicans. Franco's victory against the left-wing Popular Front government emboldened the dictators and emphasized the weakness of Western democracies.

The Reichstag Fire was a key moment in Nazi history. It led to the absolute dictatorship of Adolf Hitler and the growth of fascism, setting Europe on the path to world war. ■

Fascism across Europe

European fascism blossomed in a climate of economic disarray in the 1920s and '30s. Democracies lost legitimacy with their people, and fascist parties, offering a form of extreme right-wing nationalism, boasted that they would provide strength where weakness had prevailed.

In the 1930s, no European country, with the exception of the Soviet Union, was without a form of fascist party. Britain had Sir Oswald Mosley's British Union of Fascists (BUF). Ireland had the Blueshirts; France, Le Faisceau; and Denmark and Norway had many far-right parties. Engelbert Dollfuss's Fatherland Front was installed in Austria in 1934, while Greece was under the

rule of General Ioannis Metaxas between 1936 and 1941. Portugal and Bulgaria also came under right-wing dictatorships, as did Romania.

By the end of the 1930s, authoritarian governments had assumed power in virtually every corner of central and Eastern Europe, and democracy was in decline.